state, clinching 48 seats and an impressive 39.94 per cent vote share, was accompanied by its sweeping performance in the Hindu-majority Jammu up north, where it captured 29 seats. This resurgence comes as a balm to the party, still smarting from setbacks in the Lok Sabha election. If its tally of a perfect 10 was halved in Haryana, the ire of alienated Marathas and Dalits had seen the BJP-led alliance's LS count plummet to a mere 17 out of 48 seats in Maharashtra.

Now, with all eyes on the Maharashtra and Jharkhand assemblies, the BJP is gearing up to test the potency of its Hindutva narrative.

THE BATTLE OF NARRATIVES

- **RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat and Prime Minister Narendra Modi have emphasised Hindu unity, with the BJP leveraging this narrative in upcoming state elections**
- **The strategy aims to counter the Opposition's caste-based politics and consolidate Hindu votes across various communities**
- **The BJP's success in Haryana has bolstered its confidence, after setbacks in recent Lok Sabha polls**
- **But the party leaders and RSS *swayamsevaks* have adopted a nuanced, low-key approach, focusing on grassroots outreach and framing local issues within the broader Hindutva context**

Party insiders are quietly confident that this renewed focus will serve as a clarion call to their workforce, helping them penetrate deep into the heartlands of caste groups that are influential socially and numerically, not to mention Dalit and tribal communities that had slipped from their grasp.

This narrative didn't emerge in a vacuum. Uttar Pradesh's firebrand chief minister, Yogi Adityanath, had already set the stage with his warning amid the Bangladesh unrest: "*Batenge to katenge* (If we get divided, we'll get killed)". Yogi, too, is facing an uphill task of reviving the party's fortunes as nine assembly segments in UP head for bypolls on November 13. In the Lok Sabha election, the BJP's tally had dwindled from 62 to 37, and fingers were pointed at Yogi's working style.

The BJP's renewed push for a consolidated Hindu vote bank is seen as a calculated counter to the Opposition's caste-based stratagem. For nearly a year, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has been championing the cause of a caste census, a demand that strikes a chord with OBC and Dalit communities. The BJP leadership stands accused of neglecting backward communities, a charge they're eager to dispel. In a move that seems choreographed to bolster the Sangh Parivar's narrative, the Juna Akhara—the largest of Hinduism's 13 monastic orders—announced plans to confer the title of *mahamandaleshwar* (great spiritual leader) on 71 saints from Dalit and tribal backgrounds. This gesture of inclusion aligns perfectly with the BJP's vision of a unified Hindu society.

As the electoral battleground heats up, the BJP's foot soldiers, alongside RSS swayamsevaks, are taking this message of Hindu unity to the streets. In Haryana, this grassroots campaign helped the party make inroads into previously antagonised Jat and Dalit voters. The party's electoral strategists are tapping into a sentiment among BJP loyalists that the party's reduced majority in the Lok Sabha has weakened PM Modi's hand, allowing anti-Hindutva forces to gain ground. This includes pushback against the Sangh Parivar's vision of '*samagra samajik nyay*' (holistic social justice) under a broader Hindutva umbrella.

But learning from past missteps, BJP leaders are adopting a more nuanced approach, eschewing the provocative rhetoric that characterised their Lok Sabha campaign. The party thinks the earlier strategy backfired, unifying the Muslim vote against them while failing to consolidate Hindu support under their Hindutva banner. Now, the party and Sangh leaders are opting for a low-decibel campaign. When Bhagwat alludes to foreign hands stirring up trouble in Bangladesh or new anti-India narratives emerging there, Sangh workers take this message door-to-door, framing it as a call to strengthen PM Modi in his fight against these shadowy forces.

In Maharashtra and Jharkhand, despite the complex political landscape, party leaders are banking on this sentiment to overcome local factionalism, curtail rebellion and maximise output from their workforce. The Sangh has formed division-level committees and assembly-wise groups of 150 swayamsevaks who are engaged in grassroots outreach, discussing Modi's schemes and Hindutva issues. Recent events, such as a massive protest march by Muslim community members in Marathwada, have provided fresh fodder for this narrative. In Jharkhand, the BJP is raising alarm about interfaith marriages involving tribal women, framing it as a ploy to grab their land right under the nose of a tribal chief minister. The coming weeks will reveal whether this carefully crafted symphony of Hindu unity can drown out the competing notes of caste politics and regional dissent. ■